was receiving daily from his subordinates in DC, McCone grew more and more convinced that the Soviets had put the SAMs on the island for a reason, and the reason was to protect the delivery of much more dangerous missiles that could carry nuclear warheads. The CIA chief shared his concerns with his second in command, General Marshall Carter, who was substituting for him in Washington. The deployment of SAMs in Cuba, cabled McCone on September 10 from his French getaway, had been undertaken "for purpose of ensuring secrecy of some offensive capability such as MRBMs [medium-range ballistic missiles] to be installed by Soviets after present phase completed and country secured from overflights."[2]

Carter, a balding fifty-three-year-old officer who had made his career as an aide to General George C. Marshall in his capacities as chief of staff of the US Army, secretary of state, and then secretary of defense, did not disagree with his chief but never shared his cables with the White House. He therefore had trouble convincing other members of the administration that the situation was indeed as dangerous as McCone suggested, and that it required constant monitoring by regular flights over Cuba.

The previous few days had been anything but a success for the CIA U-2 program. Since the fateful U-2 flight of August 29 that had discovered the Soviet SAMs, CIA spy planes had received a lot of bad press around the world. On the next day, August 30, the Soviets spotted a U-2 in their air space near Sakhalin Island in the Far East. The US government apologized for the incident, and Khrushchev even expressed satisfaction with the Kennedy administration's handling of it while meeting with Stewart Udall on September 7. But the U-2 continued to cloud US-Soviet relations, as the Chinese shot down a U-2 over their territory the following day, September 8. Two U-2 accidents resulting in international scandals and public embarrassment for the US government in less than ten days could not but affect espionage operations elsewhere, and overflights of Cuba became a matter of growing concern to the State Department, which had to do all the explaining in the international arena.[3]

Secretary of State Dean Rusk asked McGeorge Bundy, Kennedy's national security adviser, for a meeting with the CIA, and Bundy obliged, passing to the CIA Rusk's questions about U-2 flights along with his